India. Indeed, there is no ‘pure’ population of Ancestral South Indian. The only populations without a large ANI input live in remote places like the Andaman Islands. Incidentally, there are also no pure ANIs.

There may be a temptation to equate the ANI–ASI data to the old Aryan–Dravidian racial theory. One should be careful doing this for a number of reasons. First, the ANI and the ASI are not ‘pure’ races in the nineteenth-century sense. Rather, they are merely different genetic cocktails that each contain many strands. Second, the terms Aryan and Dravidian are not just about genetic ancestry but carry strong cultural connotations. While the ANI genes are more widespread amongst speakers of Indo–European languages and the ASI genes in Dravidian-language speakers, there is a tendency to extrapolate this to cultural innovations of much later times. For instance, the people called Aryans are usually linked to the Vedic tradition while the Dravidians to the Sangam literary tradition. This is not meaningful to the ANI–ASI framework because we are dealing with genetic mingling that started well over 10,000 years ago, a lot earlier than the Vedic tradition, Sangam literature or the Harappan civilization. [26] We are dealing with small bands of hunter–gatherers and early farming communities rather than the thundering war-chariots, iron weapons and fortified cities that are said to have been part of an Aryan–Dravidian rivalry.

In other words, after thousands of years of mixing, Indians are most closely related to each other and it is pointless splitting hair over who is more Aryan and who is more Dravidian. The story of Manu, the Indian Noah, sums up the genetic findings surprisingly well. He was said to have been the king of the Dravidians prior to the flood but is repeatedly mentioned in the Vedic tradition as an ancestor!

A word of caution: India is a large and diverse country and there are many communities that will not fit a simple ANI–ASI framework. In the country’s north-east and along the Himalayas, for instance, we find large genetic inputs from Tibeto–Burmans. In historical times alone we know of genetic inflows of Arab, Ahom, Turk, Jewish, Iranian and European extract. The deliberate North–South axis of the ANI–ASI approach should not be expected to explain all genetic variation across the country. It is merely the